Introduction to Digital Comics

Digital Integration Teaching Initiative (DITI)
Taught by Sara Morrell and Yuntong Ji
SOCL 3441: Sociology of Health & Illness
Fall 2026, Professor Alisa Lincoln

Workshop Agenda

- Thinking critically about comic creation
- Explore three approaches:
  - Hand drawing & scanning with modifications.
  - Drawing on tablets with pens.
  - Pixton for basic comic construction.
- Best practices for digital comic creation
- Your turn: Starting your comic
- Concluding discussion

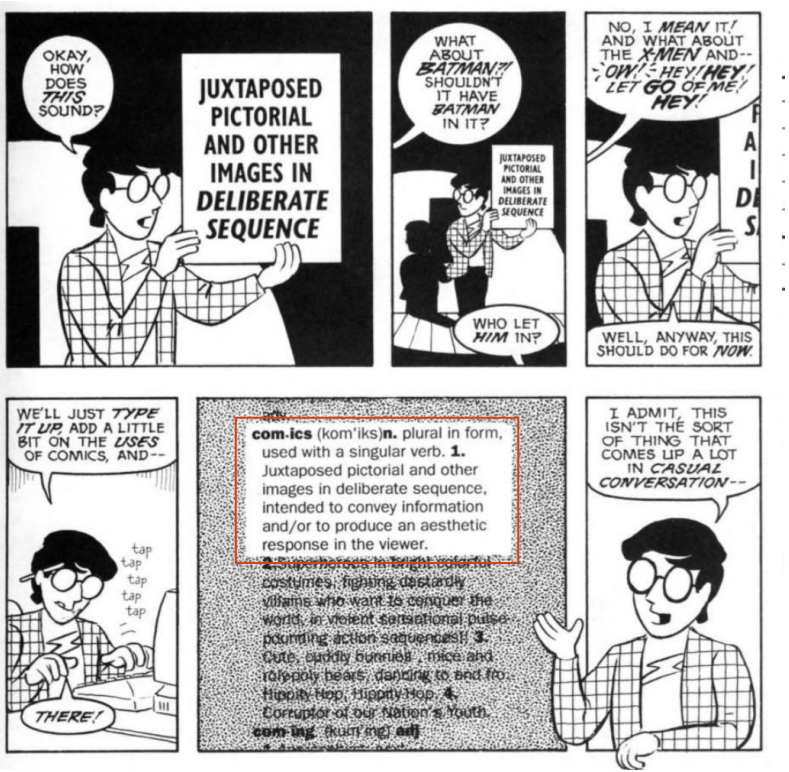
Handouts and slides are available at: bit.ly/fa26-lincoln-socl3441-digitalcomics

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Thinking Critically about Comic Creation

What are comics?



See Scott McCloud's *Understanding Comics* to explore how the comic medium defines itself, challenges our assumptions about art and storytelling, and reveals how panels, words, and images create meaning.

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Co-creation with Comics



See Other Tech Worlds Are Possible, Vol. 1, with Homeless Workers' Movement in Brazil for an example of a comic co-created by a social movement, academics, and comic-making professionals.

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Why are you making a comic?

- Before you start drawing panels, ask yourself the following questions:
  - **What** story or idea am I trying to communicate?
  - **Who** am I speaking to, and what will keep them engaged?
  - **How** do I want the reader to move through the page, and where should their eye land first?
- Comics are a mix of visuals and text, but too many characters, backgrounds, or dialogue can easily overwhelm the audience.
  - Focus on **clarity**! Each panel should help the story move forward.
  - Think of your comic as a **guided path**; you need to guide your reader through the story from panel to panel.

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Key Considerations:

- What's the central message or theme?
- Who will read this comic?
- How will your panels be arranged?
- How will words and visuals work together?
- Will you use hand-drawn sketches, digital art, or a comic-building tool?
- Is the text large and legible?
- How much time do you have? What tools are available? What is realistic for your timeline?

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Example Comics on Health + Illness:

- Wren Williams, "How I was When I First Used My Cane in Public"
- @lilaleaf, "Period Pain"
- Andy Luke, "The Sociology of Health and Illness"
- Kyle Norris, "Seattle Uses creative comic strips to help disseminate public health info"
- Meredith Li-Volmer, "Telling overdose prevention stories through comics: a conversation with the artist"



From "Climate Changes Health" by Public Health – Seattle & King County (artwork by Mita Mahato, written by Meredith Li-Vollmer)

Three Approaches to Digital Comics

Hand Drawing + Scanning + Modifications (1/2)

- Creating panels on paper using traditional drawing materials allows you to create comics using your personal style.
- Scanners (or smartphone scanning apps like CamScanner) convert your drawing into digital files (PDF, PNG, or JPEG)
- Image-editing software (such as Photoshop or Canva) allows you to enhance your drawings and add graphics or text to your comic.





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Hand Drawing + Scanning + Modifications (2/2)

Strengths

- The process is easy for those already comfortable with sketching.
- Can be combined with digital elements such as photos, graphics, or text.
- No need for advanced digital drawing skills to get started.

Limitations

- Time-intensive (drawing + scanning + editing).
- Less flexibility for quick edits once scanning is completed.
- Free versions of Canva, Photoshop, and CamScanner have limits.

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Tablet and Stylus Tools (1/2)

- Drawing tablets (such as iPads with Apple Pencil, Wacom) let you sketch directly into a digital format.
- Digital art apps (Procreate, IbisPaint, Illustrator, Krita) provide brushes, layers, and effects for flexible design.
- Export options (PNG, PDF, PSD) make it easy to share, revise, or integrate drawings into larger projects.



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Tablet and Stylus Tools (2/2)

Strengths

- No scanning required; exports as PNG, PDF, PSD.
- Apps like Procreate offer advanced tools for a polished touch.
- Layers allow for easy editing and rearranging.

Limitations

- Tablets, pens, and paid apps can be expensive if not already owned.
- Steep learning curve for students unfamiliar with digital art software.
- Files can be large and harder to share.

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Pixton (Comic Building Software) (1/2)

- Pixton is a web-based tool that allows users to build comics using drag-and-drop panels, characters, and backgrounds.
- It provides built-in templates for characters, expressions, poses, and dialogue balloons, with customization options for style and layout.
- Finished comics can be exported or shared digitally.



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Pixton (Comic Building Software) (2/2)

Strengths

- No drawing skills are required, making it very beginner-friendly.
- Customization options let students adjust characters, poses, and expressions.
- Works in-browser, so no special equipment or downloads are needed.

Limitations

- Free version restricts features and export options.
- Dialogue-heavy panels can feel cluttered in templates.
- Limited flexibility for complex or detailed artwork; not ideal for students seeking full artistic control.

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AI Considerations with Pixton

- Pixton does not use AI to generate student work
- For student accounts, it does use AI to assist in search and in checking for inappropriate content in text before reading it aloud.
- For instructor accounts, AI can be used to create a first draft of instructional materials
- Pixton “does not send personally identifiable information to our AI providers” and what information is sent is not used to train models (Source: Pixton uses AI in limited ways).

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Building your comic in Pixton

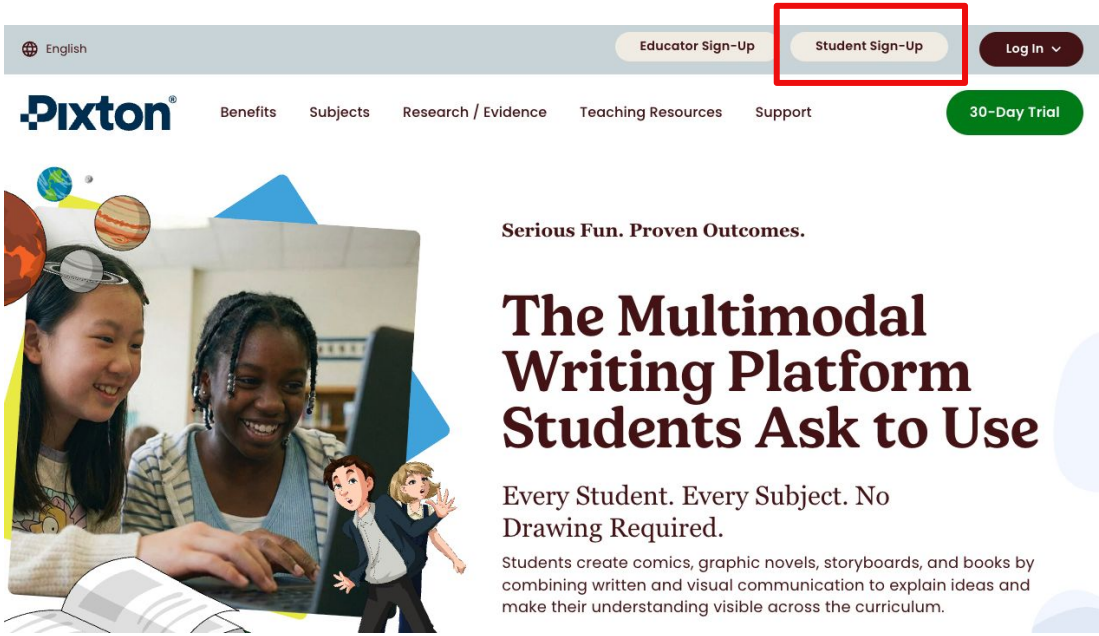
Pixton vocabulary

- **Panels:** the frames that structure your comic.
- **Characters:** customizable people/figures with adjustable poses and expressions.
- **Backgrounds:** preset locations or scenes you can drop behind panels.
- **Speech/Thought Bubbles:** text containers to show dialogue or inner voice.
- **Props:** extra objects you can insert to add context.

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Getting started

- Go to pixton.com.
- Select Student Sign-Up
- Create an account using either Google or Microsoft
- Click ‘Start my First Project’

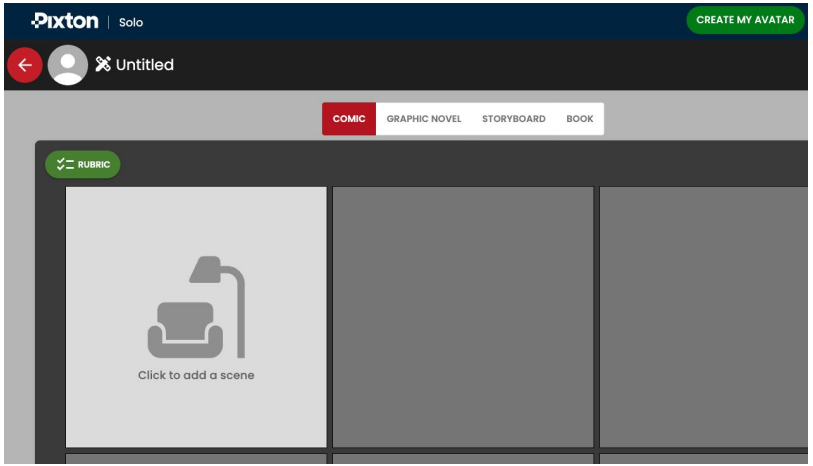


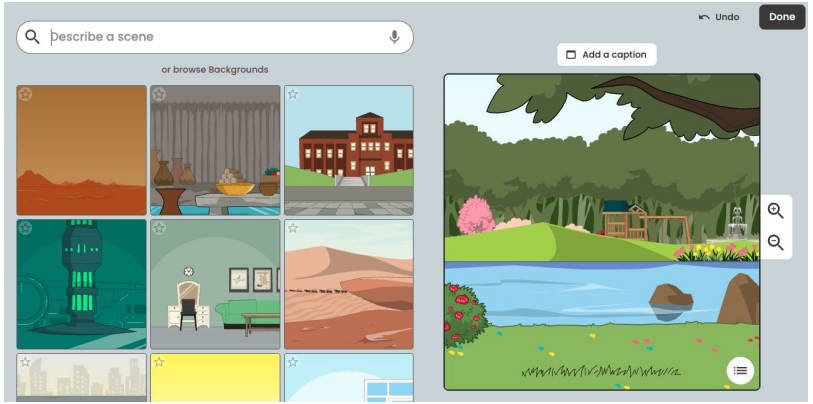
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Adding a Scene

- Select ‘Comic’ in the top menu
- Click on the top left panel to add a scene
- Select from the available scenes
- **Tip:** Keep backgrounds simple so they don’t distract from characters/text.



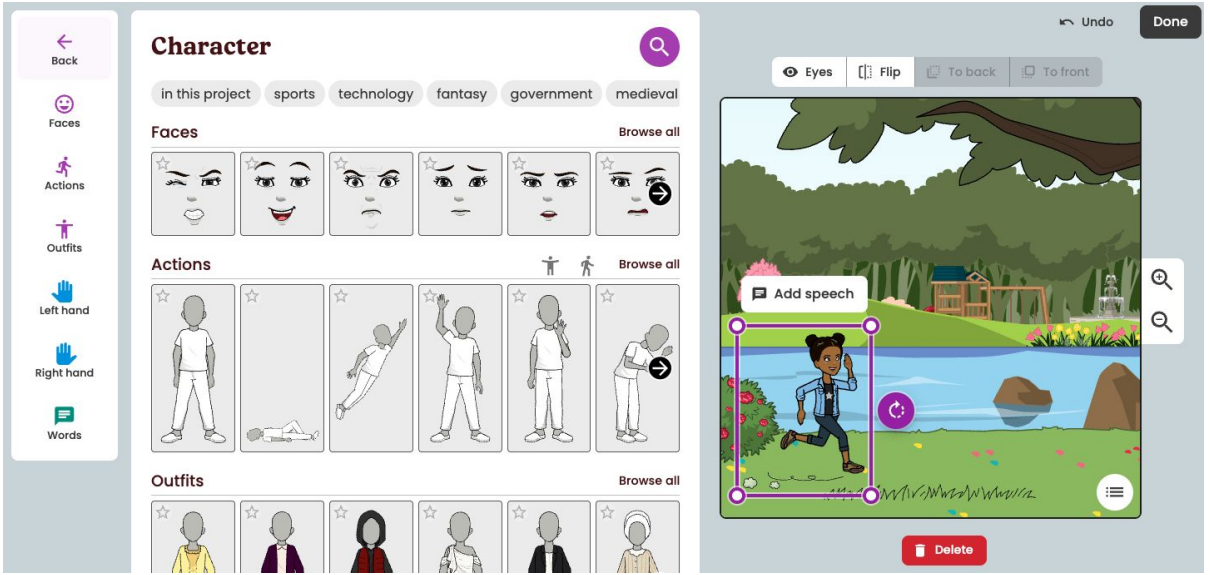


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Choosing Characters

- Choose **Characters** from the left menu.
- Customize hair, skin, clothing, and more.
- Drag into your panel and adjust position.
- Click on the character to edit their expression, action, outfit, and more using the menu on the left

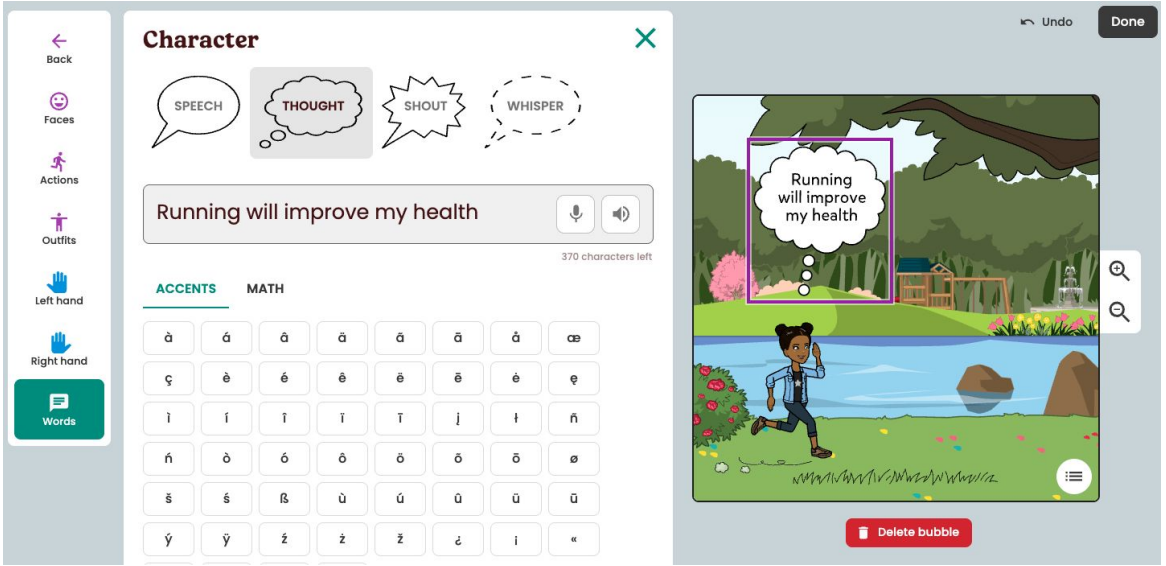


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Adding Speech

- Click the button ‘Add speech’ above the character
- Select the type of speech bubble
- Add text

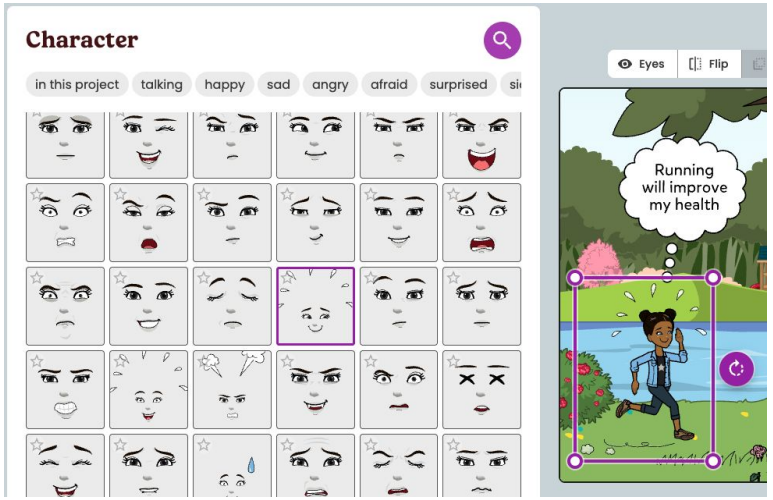


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Modifying Expressions

- The **Faces** menu lets you change your character's emotion.
- Options include happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, confusion, and more.
- Facial expressions work together with body poses to show mood and tone.
- Subtle changes (eyebrows, mouth shape, eyes) can completely shift how a scene feels.
- Expressions reduce the need for extra text.

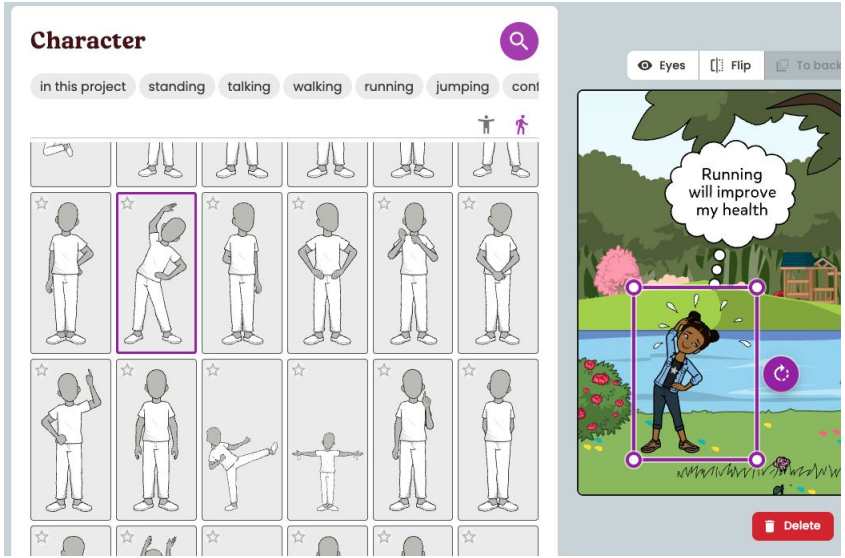


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Modifying Actions

- The **Actions** menu controls body poses and movement.
- Options include sitting, standing, pointing, running, waving, fighting, and more.
- Combine actions with facial expressions for clear storytelling.
- Actions can show what's happening without extra words.
- Helps vary panels so characters don't look static or stiff.

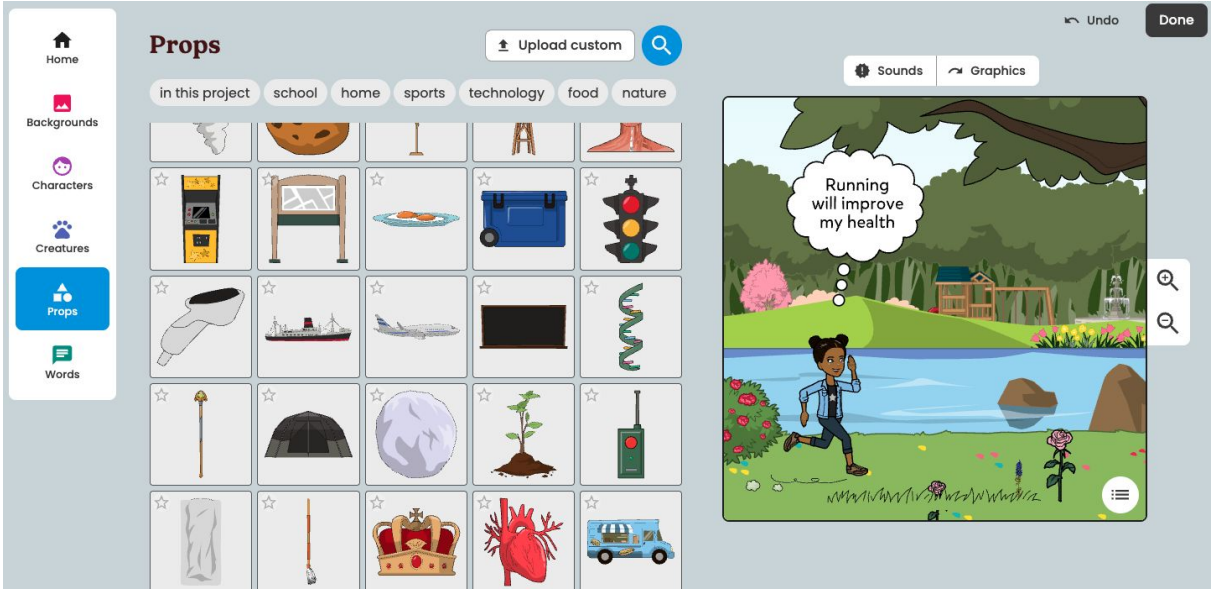


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Adding Props

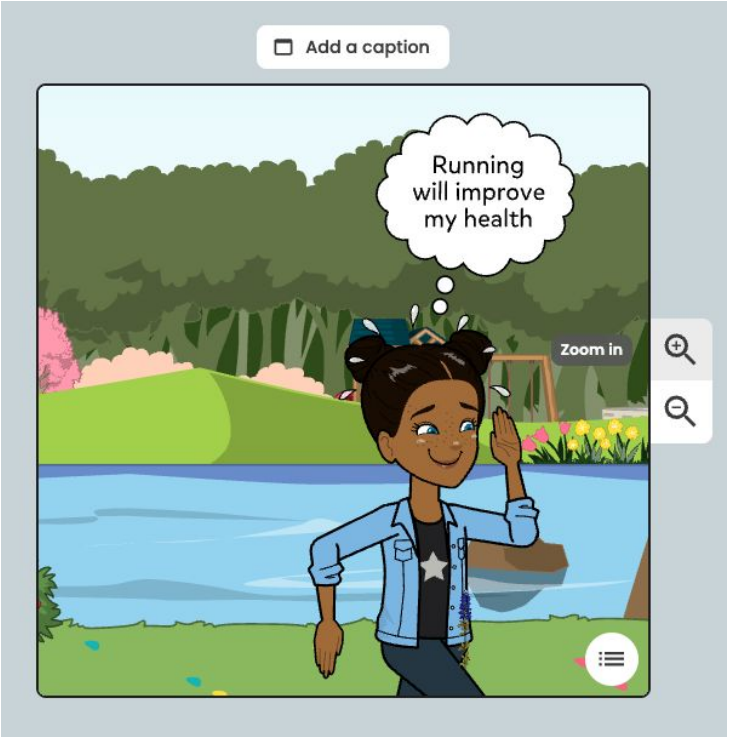
- The **Props** menu allows you to add objects into your panel.
- Click any object to drop it into your panel; resize and reposition as needed.
- You can also add Creatures by select this option from the menu



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Changing the Zoom Level

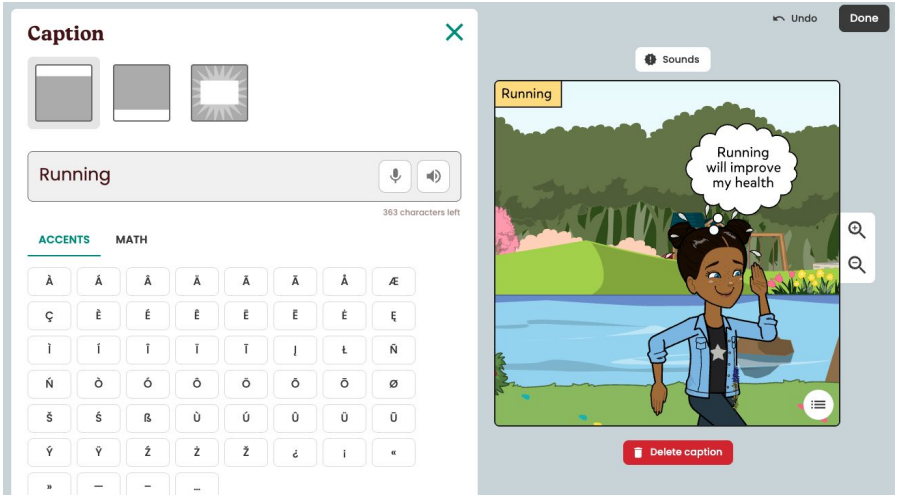
- To zoom in and out on a scene click the magnifying glass icons to the right of the image preview
- **Tip:** Use close-ups for emotions or important details and wide shots for establishing the scene.



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Adding a Caption

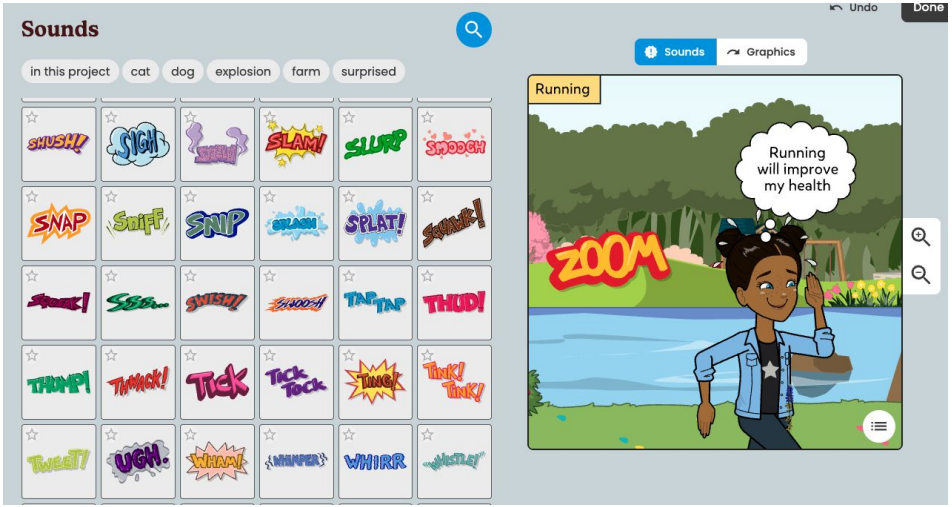
- The **Words** section allows you to add text to your comics.
- If your character is selected, you can add speech
- If nothing is selected, you can add a caption by filling in the text and selecting where you want the text to appear



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Adding Sounds

- To add Sounds (stylized words representing sounds), go to the **Words** menu then click **Sounds** above the scene preview
- Drag and drop the Sound to position it

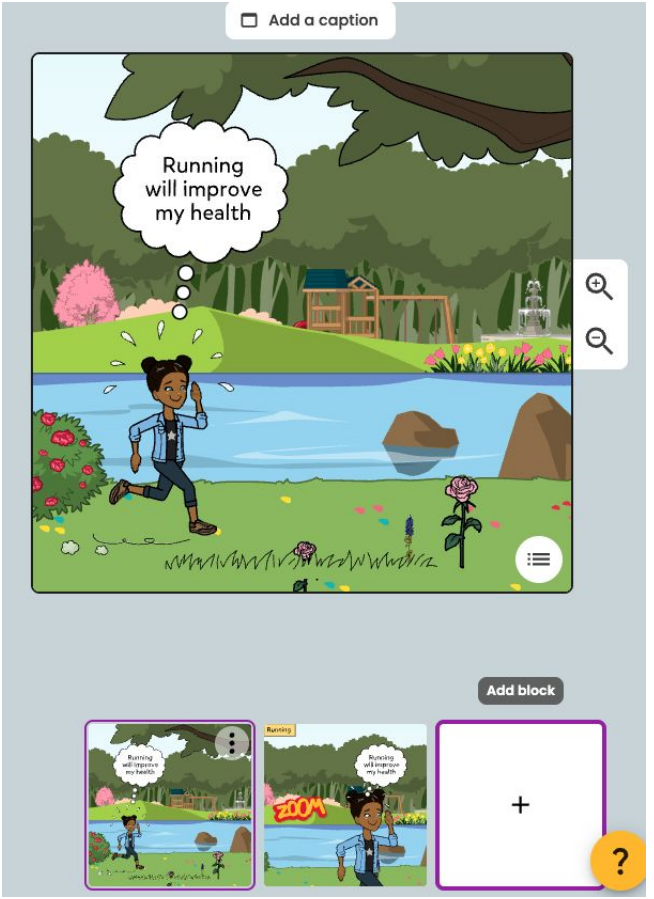


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Adding Blocks

- To add a new block, click the blank square under the scene preview
- You can then choose **Insert Blank Scene** or **Duplicate Scene**



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Exporting & Sharing Your Comic

- Click **Done** in the upper right corner
- If you have a paid account you can select **Download** to export your comic
- If not, you can screenshot your comic



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Best Practices for Digital Comic Creation

Presentation and Design

- **Always remember your audience** and think about how you want your story to connect with them.
- Use the “Preview” option to **check how your comic flows** from panel to panel.
- More isn’t necessarily better. You want your comic to be **easy to read, engaging, and visually clear**.
- Pick a panel layout and style that **fits the story** you’re telling.
- Design choices should be guided by the narrative, not just decoration.
- This is particularly important for accessibility.

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Accessibility Considerations

- For maximum readability, **keep dialogue short and use high-contrast text** and backgrounds.
- Use **clear, sans-serif fonts** (like Arial and Verdana) and avoid overly stylized or compressed lettering.
- Ensure **text is large enough**, with sufficient line spacing and letter spacing.
- Consider using **arrows, numbering, or bolded words** to help guide attention.
- Be mindful of how groups are depicted visually and in dialogue.

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Your turn: Starting your comic

Hands-on Activity

Try doing the below in Pixton:

1. Log in and start your project
2. Add a scene
3. Add a character
4. Add text

Handouts and slides are available at: bit.ly/fa26-lincoln-socl3441-digitalcomics

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Discussion Questions

- How might digital platforms change the way comics are circulated, owned, or remixed?
- What should creators keep in mind when representing cultures or identities different from their own?
- What can we do to reduce barriers so that diverse audiences can enjoy and understand our work?

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For further exploration

Handout: Accessibility in Digital Content

Handout: Copyright and Fair Use

Handout: Data Privacy

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Thank you!

— Taught by DITI Fellows Sara Morrell and Yuntong Ji

—Developed by Claire Lavarreda, Shannon Peifer, Zhen Guo and Mel Williams

- For more information on the DITI, please see: https://bit.ly/diti-about
- Schedule an appointment with us! https://bit.ly/diti-meeting
- If you have any questions, contact us at: nulab.info@gmail.com
- We'd love your feedback! Please fill out a short survey here: https://bit.ly/diti-feedback